

Tiny Microbes, Big Appetite

By

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Street food is an exciting part of Dhaka life. Nowadays Dhaka's street food has got different vibes, culture and tastes. From the crunchy and tangy bombai pani fuchka to gooey cheesy street style pizza, Dhaka's street food culture is definitely a paradise for foodies. The history of Dhaka's street food has changed over the years. It has traditional bhelpuri, jhalmuri to fusion foods such as tacos, maki rolls, dumplings, calamari fries, corndogs and even shahi dishes such as kebabs and haleem too. But what is masked behind the sound of sizzling and aromatic smell is a challenge for street food enthusiasts to think of food safety. When these foods are sold in an open and crowded environment, these questions must come to mind: are these foods safe, do microorganisms thrive in these foods and if they do, how can we find them and are we safe from them?

Street foods are exposed to air, dust, changed weathers and high traffic and crowded areas. After COVID-19 outbreak it is certain that microbes, especially pathogens do live in the atmosphere around us. A new study suggests that Bangladesh composes the most polluted air with Dhaka

securing the second position in terms of pollution. Pathogens do definitely grow as Dhaka has the most polluted air which has the factors to let pathogens grow.



The World Health Organization (WHO, 2022) states that approximately one-tenth of the world's population become ill yearly due to consumption of unsafe food, with unsafe food alone being causal for over 420,000 annual deaths.

Research conducted at the International Centre for Diarrhoeal Disease Research, Bangladesh (icddr,b) showed that coliform bacteria, *E. coli*, and *Salmonella* species have been prevalent contaminants of street-vended foods in the capital city of Dhaka (Saha et al., 2019). The pathogens contaminate on utensils, the wash water, or even on the vendor's hands when a proper practice of hygiene does not take place.

The safety of food is highly affected by temperature. Some street foods remain at room temperature for several hours, creating a conducive environment for microorganisms to grow. Book references mention that pathogenic bacteria have the ability to grow fast between a temperature of 5°C and 60°C, which is said broadly as the "danger zone" for food preservation (FAO, 2021). Under the humid climate of Dhaka, such a condition encourages microbial growth, particularly for foods such as chotpoti, fuchka, and kabab, which are normally sold without being reheated.

Public education and vendor training reduce the risk. Publicity for adherence to practices like using sanitary water, the use of gloves, and covering food for street food vendors greatly reduces contamination threats. Co-operation between local governments and public health organizations helps for routine inspections and sanitary certification of street food sellers.



The street food of Dhaka is a reflection of more than just flavor; it embodies the vibrant nature, vigor, and cultural diversity of the city. For food experience lovers, what is also important here is the realization that our enjoyment depends on the guarantee of safety for food preparation and delivery. As microbial organisms remain invisible, their preference for unsafe areas is deep-rooted. For the sustainability of street food fun, therefore, let us make hygiene our center of interest.